

◂ F/A-18 SUPER HORNET

- F/A-18 Super Hornet Block III is the most advanced, combat-proven, multi-role frontline naval fighter in the world
- Designed from its inception for carrier operations, it meets STOBAR performance requirements, compliant with both INS *Vikramaditya* and INS *Vikrant*
- Safe and proven wing-fold solution for carrier lift fitment
- It will help further the interface between manned and unmanned systems in a carrier environment
- Demanding minimal support equipment, the F/A-18 has the lowest cost per flight hour
- The US Navy's frontline fighter, with over 700 aircraft delivered around the world
- Approximate price per unit: $80 million

ANI



▲ RAFALE MARINE

- Of moderate size yet powerful and super agile, it is operated by the French Navy
- The 'omnirole' Rafale-M participates in permanent 'Quick Reaction Alert' / air defence/ air sovereignty/ deep strike missions, air support for ground forces, reconnaissance missions, nuclear deterrence duties
- It not only integrates the largest and most modern range of sensors but also multiplies their efficiency with a technological breakthrough—the 'multi-sensor data fusion'
- With two squadrons of Rafale with IAF, jet maintenance facilities in the country would be useful for Rafale-Ms
- Approximate price per unit: $200 million

Navy's sole operational aircraft carrier—using the ski-jump, or Short Take-Off But Arrested Recovery (STOBAR), technology that uses an upward curved ramp to launch aircraft, the French and the US fighters had to perform rigorous take-off and landing sorties, apart from other routines, to prove their compatibility. At the end of the tests, both the French and the Americans claimed that their respective aircraft had performed to the navy's satisfaction.

In early December, it was learnt that the navy, in its report to the ministry of defence (MoD), had stated that, compared to the Super Hornets, the Rafale-M was found to be "more suitable in meeting the operational requirements and criteria". The navy has not committed anything officially, but may have only indicated its preferred choice. However, it's not the end of the road for the Super Hornet, nor does it mean that the Americans are going to give up easily. In a deal that's worth billions of dollars, geostrategic considerations will be examined, and diplomatic pressure brought to bear upon New Delhi, before the MoD takes a final decision. In the larger context, both countries are also vying for the space in India's lucrative defence purchase market left